

## “Interrogative operator” or bias marker?

### *Nemde* in Old and Middle Hungarian questions

Cecília Sarolta Molnár

[molnar.cecilia@nytud.hun-ren.hu](mailto:molnar.cecilia@nytud.hun-ren.hu)

Proto-Hungarian is assumed to have been a head-final language, with SOV as basic word order (É. Kiss 2014). The polar interrogative marker *-e* was cliticized to the sentence-final V, so it had sentence-final position (Kenesei 1992: 692). This characteristic changed during the period of Old Hungarian (896–1526). According to the theory of É. Kiss (2014), the V-head moved to the beginning of the VP. As a consequence, the *-e* interrogative particle lost its peripheral position. This latter change is taken to have had two effects: (i) double marking with the *-e* particle: both on the V head and sentence finally, and (ii) the sentence-initial occurrence of “interrogative operators”, such as *nemde*, *minemde*, *midenem* with the V + *-e* marking. Finally, the sentence-final *-e* became redundant, and disappeared. Data from codices seem to support this theory: in most cases, *nemde* or other variants (*minemde*, *midenem*) appear sentence-initially in interrogatives marked by *-e*.

However, one should consider that most Old Hungarian data originates from the earliest Bible-translations, and biblical texts contain a great deal of non-canonical question forms (see Elbert 2004; Estes 2013; Molnár 2024) whose main function is not seeking for information, but rather conveying rhetorical or persuasive acts. Pólya (1992) claims that in Old Hungarian, interrogatives containing *nemde*, *minem*, *minemde* or *midenem* particles form a special subgroup. She collected 83 interrogatives with one of these particles from the Gospel-translations of Munich Codex (1466), then looked up their parallel loci in other Hungarian translations from the Middle Hungarian period and in the *Vulgate*. She found that the translators of the Gospels of the Munich Codex were extremely consequent with regards to the interrogative forms: most loci where *nemde* appears contain the *nonne* particle in the Latin version, and where *midenem*, or *minemde* appears, they contain the *numquid* particle in the *Vulgate*. These Latin interrogatives containing *nonne* or *numquid* do not realize neutral, information-seeking questions, but they require positive, affirmative answers.

The presentation aims at demonstrating that the use of the sentence-initial *nemde*, *minemde* or *midenem* is bound to the biased context, this type of interrogatives does not appear in neutral contexts. I will argue that *nemde* cannot be treated as a simple peripheral interrogative marker that co-occurs with the non-peripheral *-e* interrogative marker, but it is a bias-marker while *-e* remains the marker of interrogativity.

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# **“Interrogative operator” or bias marker?**

## ***Nemde* in Old and Middle Hungarian questions**

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Cecília Sarolta Molnár

[molnar.cecilia@nytud.hun-ren.hu](mailto:molnar.cecilia@nytud.hun-ren.hu)

# Introduction

## *nemde* in current Hungarian: question tag

(1) \Péter tegnap moziban volt, **^nemde?**

Peter yesterday cinema.IN was not.yes

'Yesterday, Peter was in the cinema, wasn't he?'

(2) Péter tegnap moziban volt-**e?**

Peter yesterday cinema.IN was-Q

'Was Peter in the cinema yesterday?'

(3) \*Péter tegnap moziban volt-**e**, **^nemde?**

(4) \*Péter tegnap **nem** volt moziban, **^nemde?**

(5) (**Nemde**) Péter (**nemde**) tegnap (**nemde**) moziban (**\*nemde**) volt (**nemde**)?

## *nemde* in old Hungarian: ???

(5) John 6:42a [Munich. C.]

**nemde** **ez-e** **Józsefnek** **fia**, kinek mi ismertük atyját és anyját ?

NEMDE this-E Joseph.DAT son [...]

'Is not this Jesus, the son of Joseph, whose father and mother we know?' [ESV]

(6) John 7:26 [Jordánszky C.]

**nemde** **bizony** **nal megismerték** **az fejedelmek**, hogy ez legyen az Krisztus?

NEMDE surely VM-know.PST.PL the authority.PL

'Can it be that the authorities really know that this is the Christ?' [ESV]

## *nemde* in old Hungarian: ???

(7) John 7:35b [Vizsolyi B.]

**nemde** **nem** azokhoz megyen-e, akik az görögök között eloszlottak [...]?

NEMDE not those.TO go.PRS.SG1-E [...]

'Does he intend to go to the Dispersion among the Greeks [...]' [ESV]

(8) Jn 18:33 [Munich C.]

**te** **vagy-e** a zsidóknak királya?

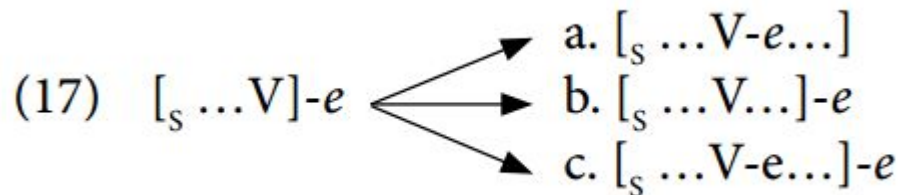
you are-E the jew.DAT king.POSS

'Are you the King of the Jews?' [ESV]

- *nemde* occurs in polar interrogatives;
- the polar interrogatives can be either positive or negative;
- always in sentence-initial position;
- only in biased contexts.

# A brief history of interrogatives

- **Uralic, Ugric:** SOV; head-final > interrogative particle at the end of the sentence
- **Old Hungarian:**
  - V-head moves to the beginning of the VP
  - **-e** interrogative particle cliticized to the V-head loses its peripheral position
    - > double marking with -e: V-e + sentence final -e
    - > **interrogative operators** at the beginning of the sentence: *nemde*, *minemde*, *midenem* + V-e; the sentence-final -e redundant > disappears



## Examples

- (16) a. **nēde** tū incab nagobbac vattoc azocnal **è**  
QPRT you rather bigger be-2PL those-ADESS Q  
'Are you bigger than those?' (Munich C. 12vb)
- b. **nemde** ɔ ańńa mondatic marianac **è**  
QPRT he mother-POSS.3SG say-PASS.3SG Mary-DAT Q  
'Is his mother called Mary?' (Munich C. 20va)
- c. **Nemde** istennek alazatot lezen en lelkem **e**  
QPRT God-DAT subjugate-PART be.3SG I soul-POSS.1SG Q  
'Will my soul be subjugated to God?' (Apor C. 7)



## Examples

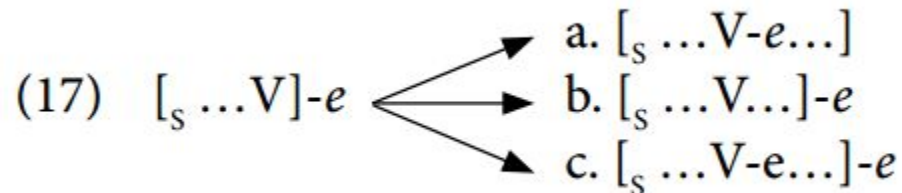
- (17) Mínemde elfelethethí-e az aña v kis  
QPRT PRT-forget-POSSIB-3SG-Q the mother she small  
gèrmøket-e  
child-POSS.3SG-ACC-Q  
'Can the mother forget her small child?'

(Nádor C. 26r)

„A (17) alatti három lehetőség közül már legkorábbi kódexeinkben is a ma is élő (17a) alatti változat az uralkodó. A (17b) típusú kérdő mondat- szerkezetben már bizonyára a mondatkezdő *nemde* tölti be a kérdő operátor szerepét; a mondatvégi *-e* a mai *vajon*-hoz hasonló választható kérdő partikula. E választható mondatvégi *-e* partikula az ősmagyar fejevű kérdő szerkezet hagyatéka.”

“Of the three options under (17), the variant under (17a), which is still in use today, is the dominant one in our earliest codices. In the interrogative sentence structure of type (17b), the sentence initial *nemde* certainly already plays the role of the **interrogative operator**; the final *-e* is an optional interrogative particle similar to the current *vajon*. This optional sentence-final particle *-e* is a heritage of the Old Hungarian head-final interrogative structure.”

[É. Kiss 2014a: 17]



“Interestingly, a clause-final *-e* — whether doubled by an *-e* on the verb or not — is always accompanied by the clause-initial negative interrogative discourse particle *(mi)nemde*. Yes–no questions framed by a clause-final *-e* and a clause-initial *(mi)nemde* seem to represent an intermediate stage in the shift from head-final to head-initial complementizers, perhaps involving two CP-layers: both a head-final one and a headinitial one. [...]

In the great majority of Old Hungarian yes–no questions, *-e* is cliticized to the verb, which presumably occupies the head position of a functional projection; i.e., *-e* appears shifted to the left periphery. (In the case of a V-adjacent *-e*, the presence of the particle *(mi)nemde* is optional.)”

[É. Kiss 2014b: 17]

“Main clause polar questions in Old Hungarian very often contained a clause-initial interrogative marker (such as *nemde* ‘isn’t it’ and *minemde* ‘isn’t it’, both containing the negative morpheme *nem* ‘not’, cf. the invariable question particle *innit* in non-standard varieties of English), and the clause-final interrogative marker *-e*: both of these were optional on their own, but whenever *-e* appeared clause-finally (unambiguously as a C head), the operator was always present and is assumed to have been obligatory in these cases (É. Kiss 2014: 16).”

[Bácskai-Atkári 2022: 122]

# Problems

- *nemde* did not become an interrogative operator
- *-e* did not disappear; it still exists in root interrogatives in certain dialects; it marks the unbiased nature of the question [see Gyuris 2017]
- *-e* is the obligatory interrogative marker in embedded questions
- *nemde* only appeared in biased contexts in Old and in Middle Hungarian

# Goals today

- Claim: *nemde* was not the marker of interrogativity (“interrogative marker”, “interrogative operator”), but it was a bias marker.\*
- Arguments: data from the Old and Middle Hungarian Bible translations.

\*Being confined to interrogatives, *nemde* can be taken to serve as a “cue” for the presence of an abstract interrogativizer, or potentially incorporate one, as Latin *nonne* does, overtly.

# Data

# Hungarian Generative Diachronic Syntax (HGDS)

|                     | root | embed | ...V-e... | ...V-e. | ...-e... | ...-e. | other |
|---------------------|------|-------|-----------|---------|----------|--------|-------|
| <b>-e</b>           | 143  | 0     | ~120      | 5       | 4        | 3      | 3     |
| <b><i>nemde</i></b> | 492  | 0     | ✓         | ✓       | ✓        | ✓      | ✗*    |
|                     |      |       |           |         |          |        |       |

- *nemde* co-occurs with -e in almost every configuration
- the Old and Middle Hungarian data come from Bible translations
- the Bible contains mostly rhetorical, pedagogical questions
- good news: we can trace back the contexts and look at other translations



## \*"Other" uses of - e in the HGDS

(9) [Konyvecse - 3v - 1/104798]\*

**ki** szakaszthatna minket el az Krisztusnak szerelmétől, háborúság-**e**, keserűség-**e**, éhség-**e**, ruhátlanság-**e**, veszedelem-**e**, ellenség-**e**, tör-**e**?

(10) [Konyvecse - 16v - 1/109325]

mert csak ő Istennek természet szerint való fia, hogy Jézusnak nevébe meghajoljon minden térd, mennyeiek-**e** földiek-**e** és pokolbeliek-**e**, és minden nyelv vallja, mert az Krisztus úr vagyon Atyaistennek dicsőségében.

(11) [BecsiK - 2/145/Dán\_6/12 - 1/40886]

király, **midőnen szerzéd-e**, hogy minden ember, ki kérend valakit az istenekből és emberekből harmincad napiglan, hanem csak tetőled, király, az oroszlánok vermébe eresztessék?

# Method

- Pólya (1992): “On some old interrogative words” [*Néhány régi kérdőszavunkról*]
  - **nemde, minem, midenem** > 83 occurrences in the Munich Codex
  - Latin **numquid** in the Munich Codex > *midenem, mindem, mindemde*
  - Latin **nonne** in the Munich Codex > *nemde*
  - The translators of the gospels in the Munich Codex were very consequent.
  - Other translators were less consequent.
- Qospel Database > the gospel of John
- Neovulgate: 169 “?”, 71 are polar interrogatives
- *numquid*-Q = 22 > Old and Middle Hungarian translations
- *nonne*-Q = 12 > Old and Middle Hungarian translations
- Hungarian translations > *nemde*
- Qospel: neutral contexts > what polar interrogative forms?

**Some examples from John's gospel**

## Numquid: Jn 4:12

- (12) a. **Numquid** tu maior es patre nostro Iacob, qui dedit nobis puteum, et ipse ex eo bibit et filii eius et pecora eius? [NV]
- b. **minem** vagy **te nagyobb** mi atyánktól, Jákobtól, ki adta minekünk e kutat, és őbelőle ivott és ő fiai és ő barmai? [MünchK]
- c. **nemde nagyobb vagy-e te** az mi atyánknál, Jákobnál, ki minekünk adta ez kutat? ő is ebből ivott, és az ő fiai és ő barmai is. [JordK]
- d. **nagyobb vagy-e te** az mi atyánknál Jákobnál, ki ez kutat minekünk adta, és mind ő maga ebből jött, és mind az ő fiai, és mind az ő barmai? [SylvesterJ]
- e. **vajon nagyobb vagy-e te** a mi atyánknál, Jákobnál, aki nekünk adta ezt a kutat, melyből ő ivott és az ő fiai és az ő barmai? [HeltaiG]
- e. **Are you greater** than our father Jacob? He gave us the well and drank from it himself, as did his sons and his livestock. [ESV]

## Numquid: Jn 4:12

**Context:** Jesus and the Woman of Samaria

<sup>9</sup>The Samaritan woman said to him, "How is it that you, a Jew, ask for a drink from me, a woman of Samaria?" (For Jews have no dealings with Samaritans.) <sup>10</sup>Jesus answered her, "If you knew the gift of God, and who it is that is saying to you, 'Give me a drink,' you would have asked him, and he would have given you living water." <sup>11</sup>The woman said to him, "Sir, you have nothing to draw water with, and the well is deep. Where do you get that living water?" <sup>12</sup>Are you greater than our father Jacob?

- Bias: speaker believes that non- $p$ ; but contextual evidence (=what Jesus said) points that  $p$ .
- contradiction; surprise (?)

## Numquid: Jn 4:29

- (13) a. **numquid** ipse est Christus? [NV]
- b. **midenem ő-e Krisztus?** [MünchK]
- c. **nemde ő legyen az Krisztus?** [JordK]
- d. **nemde ez-e ama Krisztus ?** [HeltaiG]
- e. **nem ez-e az Krisztus?** [SylvesterJ]
- e. **vajon nem az-e az Krisztus?** [Vizs]
- e. **Can this be the Christ?** [ESV]

## Numquid: Jn 4:29

**Context:** Jesus and the Woman of Samaria

<sup>24</sup>[Jesus:] “[...] God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth.” <sup>25</sup>The woman said to him, “I know that Messiah is coming (he who is called Christ). When he comes, ghe will tell us all things.” <sup>26</sup>Jesus said to her, “I who speak to you am he.” [...] <sup>28</sup>So the woman left her water jar and went away into town and said to the people, <sup>29</sup>“Come, see a man jwho told me all that I ever did. Can this be the Christ?”

- Bias: contextual evidence for  $p$ ; speaker tends to believe that  $p$

## Numquid: Jn 18:17 & 18:25

- (14) a. **Numquid** et tu ex discipulis es hominis istius? [NV]
- b. **nemde** te is ez ember tanítványai közül való vagy-e? [MünchK] !!!
- c. **nem** ez embernek tanítványai közül való vagy-e te is? [SylvesterJ]
- d. **You also are not one of this man's disciples, are you?** [ESV] !!!
- (15) a. **Numquid** et tu ex discipulis eius es? [NV]
- b. **nem** az ő tanítványainak közüle való vagy-e te is? [SylvesterJ]
- c. **You also are not one of his disciples, are you?** [ESV] !!!



## Numquid: Jn 18:17 & 18:25

**Context:** Peter Denies Jesus

<sup>15</sup> Simon Peter followed Jesus, and so did another disciple. [...] <sup>16</sup>but Peter stood outside at the door. So the other disciple [...] went out and spoke to the servant girl who kept watch at the door, and brought Peter in. <sup>17</sup>The servant girl at the door said to Peter, "You also are not one of this man's disciples, are you?" He said, "I am not."

- contextual evidence for *p*; speaker believes that *p*
- asks for confirmation?

## Nonne: Jn 18:26

- (16) a. **Nonne** ego te vidi in horto cum illo? [NV]
- b. **nemde** láttalak-**e** én tégedet a kertben ővele? [MünchK]
- c. **nemde** én téged láttalak az kertben ővele? [JordK]
- d. **nem** láttalak-**e** én tégedet az kertben amazzal ?[Sylvester]
- e. **avagy nem** láttalak-**e** én téged ővele az kertbe? [Vizs]
- f. **Did I not see you in the garden with him?** [ESV]
- stronger evidence for  $p$ ; speaker believes that  $p$

## Nonne: Jn 11:9

- (17) a. **Nonne** duodecim horae sunt diei? [NV]  
b. **nemde tizenkét idő vagy-e napjában?** [MünchK]  
c. **nemde nem tizenkét órája vagy-e az napnak?** [Vizs]  
d. **az napnak nem tizenkét órája vagy-e?** [Sylvester]]  
e. **Are there not twelve hours in the day?** [Vizs]

**Context:** The death of Lazarus

<sup>7</sup>Then after this he said to the disciples, "Let us go to Judea again." <sup>8</sup>The disciples said to him, "Rabbi, the Jews were just now seeking to stone you, and are you going there again?" <sup>9</sup>Jesus answered, "Are there not twelve hours in the day? If anyone walks in the day, he does not stumble, because he sees the light of this world. <sup>10</sup>But if anyone walks in the night, he stumbles, because the light is not in him." <sup>11</sup>After saying these things, he said to them, "Our friend Lazarus yhas fallen asleep, but I go to awaken him."

- $p$  is evidently true and everyone knows that  $\rightarrow p$  is part of the common ground;
- rhetorical question

## Neutral context: Jn 5:6

- (18) a. [...] Vis sanus fieri? [NV]  
b. [...] akarsz megvigasztod-e? [MünchK]  
c. [...] akarsz-e megvigasztani? [JordK]  
d. [...] kívánsz-e meggyógyulni? [HeltaiG]  
e. [...] akarsz-e meg meggyógyulni? [PestiG]  
f. "Do you want to be healed?" [ESV]

**Context:** The Healing at the Pool on the Sabbath

<sup>5</sup>One man was there who had been an invalid for thirty-eight years. <sup>6</sup>When Jesus saw him lying there and knew that he had already been there a long time, he said to him, "Do you want to be healed?" <sup>7</sup>The sick man answered him, "Sir, I have no one to put me into the pool when the water is stirred up, and while I am going another steps down before me."

## Neutral context: Jn 21:15

- (19) a. Simon Ioannis, diligis me plus his? [NV]  
b. Jánosnak Simonja, szeretsz-e engemet ezektől inkább? [MünchK]  
c. Jánosnak Simona, szeretsz-e engemet feljebb ezeknél? [JordK]  
d. Simon, Jónásnak fia, szeretsz-e engemet ezeknél inkább? [Vizs]  
e. Simon, son of John, do you love me more than these? [ESV]

**Context:** Jesus and Peter

<sup>15</sup>When they had ufinished breakfast, Jesus said to Simon Peter, “Simon, son of John, do you love me [diligis me] more than these?” He said to him, “Yes, Lord; you know that I love you [amo te].” He said to him, “Feed ymy lambs.”

## Jn 16:31

- (20) a. Respondit eis Iesus: "Modo creditis?" [NV]  
b. felele Jézus őnekik: **ma hiszitek?** [MünchK]  
c. mondá őnekik Jézus: **még most hiszitek-e?** [JordK]  
d. felele nekik Jézus: **mostan hiszitek?** [PestiG; Sylvester]; HeltaiG]  
e. Jesus answered them, "**Do you now believe?** [ESV]

**Context:** Speech after the last supper

<sup>29</sup>His disciples said, "Ah, now you are speaking plainly and not using figurative speech! <sup>30</sup>Now we know that you know all things and do not need anyone to question you; this is why we believe that you came from God." <sup>31</sup>Jesus answered them, "Do you now believe?..."

# Results

- Pólya (1992) ✓

|                | Munich Codex                                    | Other Codices                              |
|----------------|-------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <i>numquid</i> | <i>midenem, minemde, minem</i><br>(ex. 2 cases) | <i>nemde</i> , neg. pol. int.              |
| <i>nonne</i>   | <i>nemde</i>                                    | <i>nemde, nemde + nem</i> , neg. pol. int. |

- *nemde* only occurs as a translation of *numquid* or *nonne*
- questions with *numquid* or *nonne* are biased > different bias profiles
- *nemde* never appears in neutral contexts; in these contexts only -e interrogatives are used in the translations of the gospel of John

# Open issues

- explanation of the historical development of *nemde*
- the bias profiles of *numquid* and *nonne* in Latin
- the bias profile of the corresponding Koine Greek particles



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